Summative assessment options at Oxford

Assessment format	Assessment type	Assessment task	Description	AI-Resilient Design Strategies
Written exam	In-person, timed invigilated	Essays	A short piece of writing on a specific topic or subject	Inherently AI-resistant: device-free invigilated conditions prevent AI access. Further strengthen by using unseen questions requiring synthesis of course-specific content; designing prompts that demand personal critical positioning rather than description; and rotating question banks annually. Ensure invigilation procedures comply with Oxford's Examination Regulations.
		Multiple choice Questions	Students are required to select the correct answer from a list of possible answers	Inherently AI-resistant: device-free invigilated conditions prevent AI access. Design items at higher Bloom's taxonomy levels (application, analysis, evaluation) rather than factual recall alone. Use scenario-based or case-vignette items. Rotate question banks annually to prevent re-use.
		Short-answer questions	Open-ended questions that assess knowledge and understanding. Students may be required to complete a sentence; provide a short descriptive answer; annotate a diagram etc.	Inherently AI-resistant: device-free invigilated conditions prevent AI access. Embed course-specific diagrams, data sets, or unseen primary sources in the exam paper. Require annotation, justification of reasoning, or application of concepts to novel scenarios. Vary question parameters annually.
		Problem/computational question	Students present written solutions to problems, explaining their rationale for the approach(es) taken	Inherently AI-resistant: device-free invigilated conditions prevent AI access. Require written justification of method choices alongside calculations. Vary numerical parameters, boundary conditions, and problem scenarios annually. Include questions requiring conceptual explanation of why a given approach is valid.
		Unseen translation	A writing task that assesses competence in translation as well as understanding and application of linguistic and stylistic features in a modern or classical language.	Inherently AI-resistant: device-free invigilated conditions prevent AI access. Select passages from restricted or unpublished corpora where possible. Require a translator's commentary on stylistic and linguistic choices to assess meta-linguistic awareness that AI cannot replicate.
	Online, timed, invigilated	Essays	A short piece of writing on a specific topic or subject	Requires robust invigilation software with AI-blocking capabilities (e.g. Inspera with lockdown browser). Per Oxford's July 2025 policy, the assessment setter must declare that AI use is prohibited. Rotate question banks and use course-specific prompts; randomise question presentation across students where the platform permits.
		Multiple choice questions	Students are required to select the correct answer from a list of possible answers	Requires invigilation software with AI-blocking capabilities. Randomise question order and answer options per student using item banking. Design

				application-level, scenario-based items. Per Oxford's July 2025 policy, declare AI as prohibited and enforce via examination platform settings.
		Short-answer questions	Open-ended questions that assess knowledge and understanding. Students may be required to complete a sentence; provide a short descriptive answer; annotate a diagram etc.	Requires invigilation software. Randomise questions from a bank; embed course-specific or newly released data directly in the question paper. Require justification of responses. Per Oxford's July 2025 policy, declare AI as prohibited and ensure platform settings enforce this.
		Problem/computation questions	Students present written solutions to problems, explaining their rationale for the approach(es) taken	Requires invigilation software. Vary numerical parameters or problem scenarios per student where the platform allows. Require written justification of methods alongside calculations. Per Oxford's July 2025 policy, declare AI as prohibited with platform enforcement.
		Unseen translation	A writing task that assesse competence in translation as well as understanding and application of linguistic and stylistic features in a modern or classical language.	Requires invigilation software. Select passages not in public corpora where feasible. Require a translator's commentary on linguistic and stylistic choices. Per Oxford's July 2025 policy, declare AI as prohibited and enforce via examination platform settings.
	Online, open book timed (up to 3hrs)	Essays	A short piece of writing on a specific topic or subject	Open-book conditions make AI potentially accessible. Per Oxford's July 2025 policy, the assessment setter must declare AI permissions clearly in advance. If AI is prohibited, redesign prompts to require: synthesis of named course-specific sources; engagement with specific tutorial or seminar arguments; and a stated personal critical position with justification. Advise students to work offline where possible.
		Short-answer questions	Open-ended questions that assess knowledge and understanding. Students may be required to complete a sentence; provide a short descriptive answer; annotate a diagram etc.	Embed course-specific, recently published, or unpublished primary sources directly in the question paper. Require annotation of provided passages or application of course-specific frameworks not widely available in AI training data. Per Oxford's July 2025 policy, declare AI permissions clearly in advance.
		Case study response	Students respond to a 'real world' problem or challenge, this may involve material released in advance which the student has the opportunity to review and prepare notes on.	Design cases using novel or hyper-localised scenarios unlikely to appear in AI training data. Embed data, documents, or stimulus material within the exam paper so responses must engage directly with provided content. Require students to articulate their reasoning explicitly. Declare AI permissions per Oxford's July 2025 policy.
	Online, open book 'window' (up to 3hr exam taken	Essays	A short piece of writing on a specific topic or subject	Extended window significantly increases AI risk. Per Oxford's July 2025 policy, clearly declare AI permissions before the window opens. If AI is prohibited, mitigate by: personalising prompts to individual students' tutorial portfolios; requiring a reflective process note or annotated bibliography submitted

	during a 2 or 3 day window)			alongside the essay; specifying engagement with course-specific or unpublished sources; and, where feasible, adding a brief oral follow-up component.
		Short-answer questions	Open-ended questions that assess knowledge and understanding. Students may be required to complete a sentence; provide a short descriptive answer; annotate a diagram etc.	Use multi-part questions requiring a consistent thread of reasoning across all answers, making piecemeal AI use less effective. Embed course-specific materials, data, or unpublished sources in the paper. Require explicit justification of reasoning. Declare AI permissions per Oxford's July 2025 policy.
		Case study response	Students respond to a 'real world' problem or challenge, this may involve material released in advance which the student has the opportunity to review and prepare notes on.	Use novel, locally contextualised scenarios not accessible to AI training data. Require students to identify the limitations of generic AI-generated analysis, or to critically evaluate AI outputs as part of the task where AI use is permitted. Declare AI permissions per Oxford's July 2025 policy.
	Online, open book long duration (1, 2 or 3 days[1])	Essays	A short piece of writing on a specific topic or subject	Longest exam window: highest AI risk among written exam formats. Per Oxford's July 2025 policy, clearly declare AI permissions in advance. If prohibited, require: a reflective process commentary; engagement with course-specific or unpublished sources; and submission of an annotated plan or outline. Consider an accompanying oral follow-up component to verify individual understanding.
		Case study response	Students respond to a 'real world' problem or challenge, this may involve material released in advance which the student has the opportunity to review and prepare notes on.	Require primary data collection, fieldwork, or engagement with confidential or localised material not accessible to AI. Include a critical evaluation of AI-generated analysis as part of the response where AI use is permitted. Require a reflective process section. Declare AI permissions per Oxford's July 2025 policy.
Submission	Short duration submission (typically 5 days to 3 weeks)	Take- away or take-home essays	Essays written after teaching has been completed and in response to a list of questions or titles released at a scheduled time. Students typically have around a week to select title(s) and complete their work. Essays are	Per Oxford's July 2025 policy, declare AI permissions clearly before the assessment window opens. To strengthen resilience: personalise titles to individual students or cohort-specific material; require an annotated bibliography with reflective source notes; design prompts requiring engagement with unpublished or recently published sources not in AI training data; consider a brief oral viva on the submitted work; and require a drafting process log.

[1] Suggested pattern of release: 1 day - release at 9.30am with deadline 5.30pm, 2 or 3 days - release at 9.30am or 12.00pm on day 1, deadline of 12pm or 5.30pm on day 2 or 3. Avoiding an early morning submission deadline to discourage overnight working. Noting that 12.00pm release and deadline is more appropriate for cohorts including non-UK based students to accommodate different time zones. There would also need to be consideration of when exam deadlines could fall – e.g. weekends.

			usually of a similar length to a tutorial essay.	
		Case studies	Students find, select and argue for solutions to a ‘real-world’ problem or challenge, and either write up or orally present their findings	Design cases using real, localised, or novel problems specific to the course context. Require submission of process documentation (research notes, initial analyses). Include an oral presentation or defence component. If AI use is permitted for specific tasks, require a formal declaration per Oxford’s July 2025 policy.
		Practical reports	Concise documents used to communicate the outcomes of an experiment or small-scale project.	Tie the report to specific, original experimental data submitted alongside it (raw data files, lab notebooks, supervisor sign-off on data collection). Require a methodology justification section explaining choices made during the practical. If AI is permitted for data visualisation or write-up support, require a formal declaration per Oxford’s July 2025 policy.
		Poster assessments	A form of visual communication which requires students to concisely summarise and prioritise information and/or ideas.	Require a live oral defence or Q&A at the poster presentation, directly testing individual understanding that AI cannot replicate in person. Include original data or primary research evidenced on the poster. Require a reflective process statement. Declare AI permissions per Oxford’s July 2025 policy.
		Business plans and design proposals	Documents which set out to persuade potential funders of the feasibility and profitability of a new product or service, and how this will be achieved	Require a live oral pitch or defence before examiners. Embed a client brief or scenario specific to the course that AI is unlikely to have been trained on. Require process documentation (drafts, research notes, client communication). Per Oxford’s July 2025 policy, declare AI permissions; if AI is used for specific tasks (e.g. financial modelling), require a formal declaration.
		Translations	Assess competence in translation as well as understanding and application of linguistic and stylistic features in a modern or classical language.	Select source texts from restricted, unpublished, or recently published corpora. Require a translator’s commentary explaining linguistic and stylistic choices, demonstrating meta-linguistic reasoning AI cannot replicate. Per Oxford’s July 2025 policy, declare AI permissions clearly in advance.
	Long duration submission (typically more than 3 weeks)	Dissertation/Thesis	Extensive pieces of work based on supervised independent research or investigation. The title and focus are often developed by the student. Often completed at the culmination of the degree programme.	Per Oxford’s July 2025 policy, supervisors must declare AI permissions for the specific work. Build in regular supervision with documented process evidence (meeting logs, iterative drafts). Require engagement with primary sources, original fieldwork, or novel data. A viva voce examination provides the most robust verification of individual understanding. Require an AI use declaration in the final submission per Oxford’s academic conduct regulations.
		Extended essays	A longer essay written on a topic of the student’s choice. Can be written in response to pre-set questions, or on a title the student has developed. Students usually receive a limited amount of	Personalise titles in collaboration with supervisors to ensure specificity to the student’s own research. Require a process portfolio (research notes, annotated bibliography, drafts). Per Oxford’s July 2025 policy, declare AI permissions clearly; if permitted for specific tasks, require a formal declaration in the submission. A brief oral follow-up may be appropriate.

			supervision and may be entitled to feedback on draft work.	
		Mini-projects and structured projects	Building on skills developed through problem sheets, students are challenged to address more open-ended questions, extend a known result, or work with an industry partner on a problem. Mini-projects are typically released after teaching is completed and conducted over several weeks; structured projects run over a longer time period and with supervision.	Require submission of lab notebooks, computational code, or process logs demonstrating iterative problem-solving. Regular supervisor check-ins and milestone reviews build process evidence. Per Oxford's July 2025 policy, declare AI permissions; if AI coding or analysis tools are permitted, require formal declaration and critical evaluation of outputs.
		Fieldwork, site, museum and industrial visit reports	Assess students' learning through fieldwork, a site or museum visit, or an industrial visit. Generally presented in a clearly structured format.	Inherently tied to a specific physical experience AI cannot replicate. Require: dated field notes or observation logs; photographic or material evidence of attendance; and personal critical reflection on the experience. Per Oxford's July 2025 policy, declare AI permissions for the write-up phase.
		Portfolio	A collection of shorter pieces of work chosen by the student to demonstrate their competence and interest in a particular area.	Require a reflective commentary on the selection and development of pieces, explaining the student's learning trajectory over time. Include pieces tied to specific practical sessions or tutorials. Require process evidence (drafts, iterations). The curation rationale and personal reflection are harder for AI to replicate authentically. Declare AI permissions per Oxford's July 2025 policy.
		Research papers and articles	Work follows the format and conventions of a published paper or article in the field, often following the brief of a particular journal.	Require primary research, original data, or a novel argument developed through independent inquiry. Build in a peer review simulation involving oral feedback. Per Oxford's July 2025 policy, declare AI permissions; if used for specific tasks (e.g. literature searching, data visualisation), require formal declaration and critical evaluation of AI outputs.
		Business plans and design proposals	Documents which set out to persuade potential funders of the feasibility and profitability of a new product or service, and how this will be achieved	Require iterative process documentation across the project period, supervision or mentoring logs, and an oral pitch or defence. Per Oxford's July 2025 policy, declare AI permissions; if AI is used for financial modelling or design, require a formal declaration and critical evaluation of outputs.
		Translations	Assess competence in translation as well as understanding and application of linguistic and stylistic features in a modern or classical language.	Select source texts from restricted or unpublished corpora. Require a substantial translator's introduction and commentary demonstrating meta-linguistic reasoning. Supervision logs provide process evidence. Per Oxford's July 2025 policy, declare AI permissions for both the translation and commentary phases.

Oral, practical and/or performed exams	Practical tests and simulations	Various	Students are observed conducting a series of defined tasks within a specified period of time, and are assessed against a set of pre-determined assessment criteria	Inherently AI-resistant: AI cannot perform physical or observed practical tasks. Vary scenarios across cohorts and years; use randomised task sequences. Assess using standardised rubrics with observer verification. Per Oxford's July 2025 policy, declare any relevant AI permissions (e.g. AI-assisted diagnostic tools) if applicable to the discipline.
	Oral presentation	In relation to a case study, research project or paper etc.	Assess student's knowledge and understanding, as well as their ability to communicate orally and visually. The audience may include peers and members of the department. May be performed live or pre-recorded.	Live delivery with real-time examiner Q&A is inherently resistant to AI impersonation. Where pre-recorded formats are used, add a mandatory live follow-up session. Vary prompts across students. Per Oxford's July 2025 policy, declare AI permissions for the preparation phase (e.g. AI slide-generation tools); if permitted, require a formal declaration.
	Viva voce and interviews	In relation to a dissertation or thesis	Oral examinations of students' understanding of submitted written work or a written examination, and its wider implications. The format may be formal and structured or less formal and dialogic.	Inherently the most AI-resistant format: directly tests individual oral understanding in real time. Design questions that probe beyond the submitted text into wider implications, spontaneous application, and personal intellectual development. Use unpredictable follow-up questions. Per Oxford's July 2025 policy, declare any AI permissions relating to the submitted work under examination.
	Performances, exhibitions and displays	Musical performance	Assess students' practical application of understanding and knowledge. Allow students to communicate their creative practice to wider audiences.	Live performance is inherently AI-resistant. Individualise programme selection or include improvisatory elements requiring artistic choices. Where pre-recorded performances are accepted, add a live oral commentary or defence. Per Oxford's July 2025 policy, declare AI permissions for any composition or arrangement work accompanying the performance.
		Exhibition of created work		Require a process portfolio (sketches, drafts, iterations, studio notes) demonstrating individual creative development. A live oral commentary or defence at the exhibition directly verifies individual understanding. Per Oxford's July 2025 policy, declare AI permissions for any AI-assisted creation tools; if permitted, require a formal declaration of AI-generated versus student-created elements.
	Objective Structured Clinical Examinations (OSCEs)	Various	Students undertake a series of tasks in sequence to demonstrate a range of skills and competencies in authentic contexts	Inherently AI-resistant due to real-time, multi-station, physical format. Strengthen by varying station scenarios annually; using standardised patients who can adapt dynamically to student responses; and including stations assessing professional communication and clinical reasoning under time pressure. Declare any AI permissions relevant to preparatory simulation tools per Oxford's July 2025 policy.
	Aural examination	Various	A series of exercises that assess students' listening skills, typically	Inherently protected by live or closely invigilated conditions. Vary stimulus material (musical passages, spoken texts) annually. Include improvisatory or

			in relation to language or musical competency	spontaneous response tasks. Per Oxford’s July 2025 policy, AI use must be declared as prohibited and enforced via examination conditions.
	Oral examination	Various	A series of exercises that assess students’ verbal skills, typically in relation to language competency	Inherently AI-resistant when conducted live: spontaneous real-time language production cannot be AI-assisted. Include unpredictable prompts requiring live linguistic production. Vary topics and registers annually. Per Oxford’s July 2025 policy, AI use must be declared as prohibited. Where pre-recorded elements are used, add a mandatory live follow-up component.

Editorial note: AI resilience should be understood as a spectrum rather than an absolute state. The most robust assessment designs combine appropriate assessment formats, clear communication of permitted AI use, authentic disciplinary tasks, iterative process evidence, and proportionate verification of student understanding. Departments should ensure that any implementation remains consistent with current Oxford Examination Regulations, local faculty guidance, accessibility requirements, and student workload expectations.